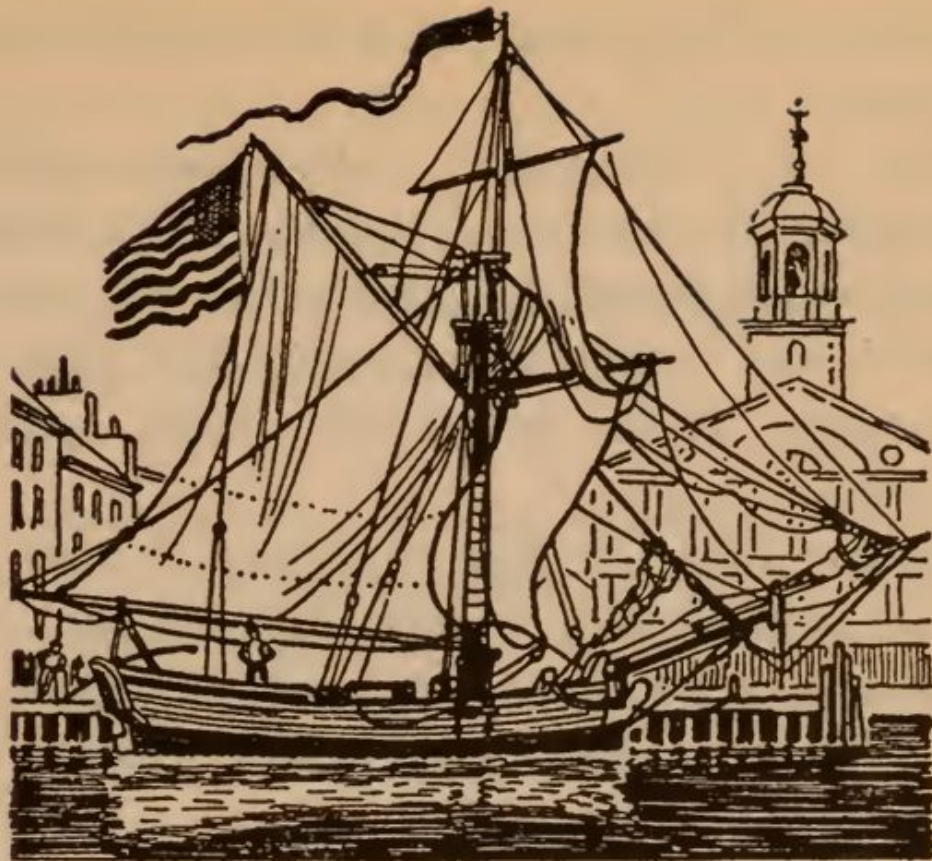


Carry On, Mr. Bowditch

Chapter 22



CHAPTER 22



SCIENCE AND SUMATRA

Dr. Holyoke went with Nat to see the crew and get word of the *John*. There was no doubt about the loss. Polly was waiting for them when they returned. She knew what rankled in Nat's mind — beyond the loss and the disappointment.

“Don't think about what Zack Selby said, dear — about books. Who's Zack Selby?”

Dr. Holyoke sighed. "He speaks for a lot of men, Polly. I'm not saying there are many as mean-spirited as he is — thank heaven. But there are hundreds — thousands — who don't believe in 'book sailing.' You know, seafaring is a lot like medicine. On the one hand — superstition and old wives' tales; on the other hand — the scientist, trying to solve the puzzles and find the answers. And all through the ages men have believed the superstitions and doubted the scientist. Natural, I suppose. You believe what you grow up believing. It's hard to change.

“You can’t remember, Polly, when we first started inoculating for smallpox.” He shook his head. “Wonder to me I wasn’t lynched. Inoculation was risky — but not as bad as the epidemics of smallpox. Then vaccination came along. It was safer, but people raised almost as much fuss.

“All my life, I’ve felt as though I made three steps forward with science, and got dragged back two steps by the ignorance and superstitions of mankind. And every time a doctor ‘loses’ a patient, no matter why, it gives science another setback.”

“And every time a ship is lost,” Nat added, “it gives scientific navigation a setback, too. Men blame the books. They’ve been right to blame them, sometimes. There have been errors in the books. And when you depend on a book and it has a mistake, you’d have been safer not depending on it.”

“But your book isn’t going to have mistakes!” Polly said. “When men depend on it — ”

Nat didn’t smile. “It will take a long time to convince them.”

Dr. Holyoke nodded.

Polly protested, “But after what the East India Society said — ”

Dr. Holyoke smiled wryly. "That ought to convince all America — but Salem. A prophet is without honor in his own country, you know."

"What if England accepts the book? That would convince even Salem, wouldn't it?"

Nat laughed, but shook his head. "You could never convince an Englishman that anything out of America was better than something made in England."

"Never?" Polly asked.

"Not a chance!" Nat told her.

Late in March, Dr. Holyoke brought them a Newbury paper. "Listen to this!" He read:

“To the honor of the scientific knowledge of Mr. Nathaniel Bowditch of Salem, Mass., we are informed that one copy of his *New American Practical Navigator* was sold in London to two nautical booksellers by Mr. Blunt of this town, for 200 guineas, and an edition of 6,000 copies is now in press. Moore’s *Practical Navigator* has depreciated very much in that country, owing to the numerous errors which have been fatal to mariners.”

Polly's eyes glowed. "There, Nat! Who said England would never accept an American book? I guess the world will believe you now!"

"Maybe," Nat said, "if I'd been a sailing master myself, in full command of a ship . . ."

He said no more. But early in the summer he came home with something on his mind. He had been asked to go as captain, supercargo, and part owner on a voyage to Sumatra and the pepper islands. "I had a long talk with Mr. Lawrence today," he told Polly. "He has his eye on a new vessel — the *Putnam* . . . Well, Polly?"

Polly caught her breath, then smiled. "Master and supercargo, both? Captain Bowditch, you'll be a busy man!"

Nat hugged her. "Bless you, Polly."

He soon found he was a busy man. Preparations for the voyage kept him running here, there, and everywhere. In August, he had to make a trip to Boston. "I'm sailing in Miller's sloop," he said. "Lots more pleasant than a stagecoach in August."

"It'll help you get your sea legs again," Polly said. "Have a good trip."

"I shan't be long," Nat promised. Miller promised, too, "I'll have him back in short order, Mrs. Bowditch!" And they made the trip down in good time. But the morning they were ready to leave Boston, they were becalmed.

Miller was disgusted. "Of all the infernal luck," he growled. "I promised your wife I'd have you back in short order. Now look at me! Becalmed!"

On a sudden impulse Nat said, "It suits me fine. To-day is Commencement Day at Harvard. I've always intended to go."

Miller eyed him suspiciously. "You're not just saying that to make me feel good?"

“No,” Nat told him, “I’ve always wanted to go.”

But when he sat alone in the crowd, and watched the fresh-faced boys getting their degrees, he knew it had been a mistake to come. It only brought back a heart-ache that was better forgotten. Harvard . . . Harvard men . . . In spite of everything the buried memories rose up to nag him.

Again he was a boy of twelve, sitting at the breakfast table, filled with bubbling joy because he was going to go back to school — he thought. Again he saw the frown on his father’s face, and the tired shadows under Mary’s

eyes. Again he saw the paper that had sealed his fate for nine years: *Nathaniel Bowditch — Indentured.*

From the platform President Willard's voice interrupted Nat's thoughts. He heard a name that sounded something like *Bowditch*, dressed up in Latin. Some relative? Nat wondered.

When the ceremonies had ended, Nat walked slowly out into the sun again. He'd been a fool to come. He straightened, and tried to throw off the depression. "Forget it!" he told himself.

Behind him someone called, "Nathaniel Bowditch!"

He turned. The years had whitened the man's hair, but Nat recognized him — the Mr. Morris who had offered him a chance to tutor his children — if he could have been free to leave the chandlery.

Mr. Morris gripped his hand. "Congratulations, Mr. Bowditch!" He put his arm around a young man's shoulders. "My son, John." He said, "John, this is Mr. Bowditch — the man I was telling you about! The man who got a degree from Harvard without ever setting foot in a classroom!"

"What?" Nat said.

"Didn't you hear them award it this morning? *Nathaniel Bowditch, A.M.*"

“I — I — suppose I was thinking of something,” Nat said. In a happy daze he listened while Mr. Morris talked. In a happy daze he smiled and answered the boy’s questions. *Nathaniel Bowditch — Harvard man!*

That night when he turned in, he lay smiling into the darkness. This, he told himself, was the proudest day of his life.

He had been home in Salem a few days when the letter came from Harvard:

Cambridge, August 31, 1802

Sir,

I have the pleasure of informing you officially that on Commencement day, the 25th instant, the degree of Master of Arts was conferred on you. It gives me further pleasure to acquaint you that this degree was unanimously voted by the Corporation of the University, and unanimously confirmed by the Overseers. . . .

I am, sir,

with much esteem

your very humble servant

JOSEPH WILLARD

President of Harvard College

Nathaniel Bowditch, A.M.

Polly said, "Oh, Nat! If only we could paint that on the *Putnam*! CAPTAIN BOWDITCH, A.M., COMMANDING"

Nat chuckled and hugged her. Bless Polly. He hadn't thought anything could make him happier than he had been on the twenty-fifth. But Polly had a way of sharing things.

"Come along up to my study," he said. "I have papers to sort. Work goes so much faster when you're there, too."

They were working that night in his study when someone hammered on the front door. They heard a hoarse shout, "Ahoy the ship!"

Polly jumped to her feet. "Something's happened!"

"Someone's been splicing the main brace," Nat guessed. "I'll quiet him." He raced down the stairs, but not before more hammering fairly shook the house.

"Ahoy the ship!"

"I'll ahoy you," Nat muttered and flung open the door. "Just what the . . . Lem! Lem Harvey! Come in, man! Come in!" And Nat was bellowing as loud as Lem.

“Polly! Come down and see who’s here!”

Lem crushed Nat’s hand and pounded his back and bellowed with cheerful profanity, “I knew there was one man in Salem who wouldn’t think I was a ghost.”

Nat wiggled his fingers to see if they still worked. “You’re flesh and blood, all right, and bone and muscle! Come in, man, and sit down!”

Lem was too excited to sit down. He grinned at Polly, and paced the floor as he told his story. “When the *Betsy* struck, and we launched the boats, I headed straight out from land.”

Nat said, “Good man!”

“There was six of us, when we started.” Lem stopped for a moment. “I guess if the storm had let up, so we could have told where we were . . . But for two days we didn’t do anything but fight the sea and bail that boat. Then . . . fog.” He stood a moment, his shoulders slumped, staring into the past. “Man, were you ever lost in a fog? That’s when they started cracking up. The first one . . .”

Polly shuddered.

Lem glanced at her and then skipped. “Well, the upshot of it was that I was picked up by the *Julius*, bound for Sumatra. What a journey that was. Everything that could happen to one ship happened to the *Julius*. But

when we got to Sumatra, we did all right. The captain really got himself a cargo of pepper. And I got this!" He whipped out a short dagger with an ivory handle and a wavy blade.

"What in the world?" Polly asked.

"It's a creese, ma'am. A Malay dagger. They got all sizes and shapes — long, short, wavy, straight. But this is the one that works fastest. I was on anchor watch when I sort of *felt* something behind me. Didn't hear a thing! The way those brown devils can — begging your pardon, ma'am — can swarm up the cable . . . Well, anyhow, *he* got it instead of *me*, and then *I* got it . . . if you understand what I mean. I grabbed it, and — "

Nat interrupted hastily. "You say the captain did all right in Sumatra? A good cargo of pepper?"

"Yes, sir!"

"Would you like to go to Sumatra again?"

Lem stared. "Me? No, sir! Once is enough! If you ask me, once is too often!"

"Because of the way they fight?" Polly asked.

Lem shrugged. "Oh, that? That's not the half of it. You see, ma'am —"

Nat interrupted quickly again. "I'd like to talk to you about the business end of it, Lem. How they —"

Lem shook his head. "I don't know much about that part of it. All I know is that the captain and his clerk

went ashore every day there was trading to do. Rest of us — we stayed on board and kept our fingers crossed that they'd get back! You see — ”

Again Nat tried to haul him around on another tack. “Uh — how was the scenery?”

Lem shrugged again. “Full of trees . . . with a betel-chewing Malay behind each one. Remember the first time we saw a fellow chewing betel? And when he spit, it looked like blood? Man, you'd think the fellow's throat was cut. But they don't generally go for the throat with these daggers. They rip right into — ”

It was no use. Nat said, "I'm sorry you wouldn't like to make another trip to Sumatra, Lem. I'm leaving soon for there, myself. Commanding the *Putnam*."

A grin split Lem's face. "You? Why didn't you say so? If you're going, I go, too! I'll sign on as anything from second mate to cook!"

Polly looked at him, puzzled. "But you said —"

Lem's gesture tossed it aside. "Aw, that was just *talk*. I was just — just — spinning yarns. Sumatra's fine. Pretty country. Real pretty."

"And the people?" Polly asked.

Lem scratched his head. "Uh — the people?" He looked at the dagger in his hand. "Uh — I'll bet they're nice, too, ma'am, when a fellow gets to know them. Now take this fellow that — uh — that I got the creese from. Probably wasn't anything *personal* about it. He didn't really have anything against me. It was just — just — " For a moment he was stumped, then he grinned. "Maybe he just run amuck! You know, they do that. All at once, they just get tired of living, and they go crazy. They start out with a whoop and a holler, knifing left and right, till someone . . ." He stopped again. "Look here,

I'm keeping you folks up too late." He ambled to the door. "Remember, Captain Bowditch, I'm signing on the *Putnam*! Yes, sir! Now I'll clear for home, so you can get some sleep!" He grinned at them, saluted — with his dagger — and was gone.

Polly shuddered and hid her face in her hands. "So *we can get some sleep* . . . he says! Oh, Nat!"

"Now, you mustn't mind the things Lem said. All sailors — "

"It wasn't what he said," Polly told him. "It was what he skipped. But I'm glad he wants to go with you."

"Yes," Nat agreed. "He's a master hand with the guns, and when — I mean, he's an all-round — "

“Nathaniel Bowditch!” Polly was stern. “Don’t you start skipping things, too!”

Nat promised.

In November, a week before the *Putnam* was to sail, a boy stopped with a message for Nat. “Dr. Holyoke says to tell you he has it ready, sir.”

Polly looked worried. “Is something wrong, Nat?”

“No, no! Just some supplies for the *Putnam*. Come along with me.”

Dr. Holyoke was waiting for them. Polly smiled at him. “Dr. Holyoke, you’re amazing; you could pass for fifty!”

Dr. Holyoke said, "Bosh!" But he grinned. "Thing that keeps me fit is keeping busy. I'll probably die with my boots on. Doctors and sailing masters . . . Humph. Well, here it is, Nat." He opened a small wooden chest. "Some of everything you might need."

Polly gasped. "All that medicine? Is Nat sick?"

"No, no, child." Dr. Holyoke chuckled. "It's for his crew. When a ship's off soundings, the captain's on his own. 'Doctor, lawyer, merchant, chief.' " He looked down into the chest. His eyes twinkled. "Plenty of jalap

there, Nat. Best thing in the world — if a man tries to soldier on you and play sick. Good dose of jalap. Don't think you'll have any trouble, though. Good men. I don't know about old Chad's grandson, Corey. Little skittery yet. Not enough keel there, or something. He'll probably work out, though."

Polly said, "Nat's depending a lot on Lem. I understand Lem's a good man with the guns."

Dr. Holyoke nodded. "Yes, and when you're in Sumatra . . . Humph. Now, let me see? Anything I forgot? Jalap, Peruvian bark, and — "

The door opened and Amanda Harvey stumbled into the room, panting. She needed the doctor right away. Lem had broken his leg.